

The first and foremost question you may ask yourself is, “Why should I care about writing a book? Is the amount of effort and time I put into the task, worth it?”

Here are some important reasons why you should consider writing your first technical book.

Reason 1: Get known

Writing a book earns you visibility, credibility and respect. A technical book will give you visibility in your area of work. You also enhance your credibility amongst your colleagues, friends and even relatives. Remember that most people consider authors of technical books as experts, and this perception matters. For example, you may get invited to give talks or keynotes and conduct seminars or training programmes if you become well known in your domain.

Reason 2: Learn and gain expertise

One of the best ways to learn and gain expertise in the topic you are interested in is to write a book on the subject! Realistically, writing a book will require you to focus on a specific topic for many months. If you choose a topic you are passionate about, you will get to learn about it. What's more, it's fun to spend time on something that you love, and that's a huge reward in itself!

Reason 3: Earn some extra income

When you write a book and publish it (through a traditional publisher), you get a regular income from royalty. Depending on the publisher and the terms of your contract, you will get these returns every three to six months, or on an annual basis. In India, royalty income up to Rs 300,000 is deductible from income tax (Section 80QQB)! When you have a day job and are earning a regular salary, this royalty becomes a secondary income (and any extra cash is always welcome, right?).

Reason 4: Get a sense of achievement

Writing a book requires commitment, focus and effort. When you finally deliver the manuscript to the publisher, you get a sense of having achieved a concrete result or crossed an important milestone. Look at writing your book as expressing your passion. Once you have written a book, you are always considered an author, and that adds weight to your resume. If you make it big, you can even leave behind a legacy.

In my experience, most people who love reading books are also interested in writing books of their own. However, what stops them from writing a book is their lack of knowledge (or fear) about the writing process. On a light note, here is a quote from *Alice in Wonderland* that describes the writing process: “Begin at the beginning, the King said, very gravely, and go on till you come to the end: then stop.” But I admit this isn't quite helpful if you are writing a book for the first time; so let us discuss the writing process in a step-by-step manner.

The writing process

Step 1: Getting an idea for a book

The first step when writing a book is to choose the right topic. Your ideal topic would be something that matches your interests, your skills and the market's need. For example, assume that you are interested in programming languages and your skills are related to creating mobile apps or writing games. Now, you need to find out the market's needs—what kind of technical books are in demand? To do that, analyse trends using Google analytics/trends, check the best-selling books in Amazon, find out about upcoming technologies from newspapers and blogs, etc. Now, you may find that books on certification, open source and those related to finding jobs are in high demand. By matching your interests and skills with what the market needs, you may find that ideally, the topic you ought to write on is developing games for Android using Java.

Step 2: Develop content

Once you finalise the topic of your book, you need to start working on developing the contents. Ignore the advice mentioned in *Alice in Wonderland* since it is a bad idea to directly start writing from the first to the last page! You can be creative regarding this part. When I write a book, I do various *other* things, apart from writing, yet all my efforts are focused on the topic of the book—I offer training sessions on the topic, write articles and blogs related to it, take notes when experimenting, read books on that topic, and even give presentations to my colleagues. In this way, I acquire content that has been looked at from various perspectives and keep getting feedback as I develop the book.

Step 3: Fill the book proposal form

Once you have a specific topic for a book and a fairly decent amount of content, it is the right time to talk to a publisher. You may opt to self-publish (these days, an increasingly large number of authors are taking this route), but I would recommend that you publish your first book with an established publisher. Why?

1. It will help you understand how to turn your draft into something that is ‘production quality’.
2. It will give you credibility among readers. People perceive getting published from a well-known publisher as a seal-of-approval for your work and will consider it seriously. As a first-time author, if you self-publish, that work is unlikely to be taken seriously.

Check out books in the market that are similar to the one you are writing to find out the names of publishers interested in your topic. Then go to their website or contact an editor from that publishing house and get the book proposal form (BPF). This is a sort of ‘application’ to the publisher about the book you are writing. The contents of this form will help the publisher decide on whether or not to take on your book.